

National Management Group Communiqué:

High Pathogenicity Avian Influenza (H5 bird flu) – 21 July 2026

On 21 July 2026, the National Management Group (NMG) committed to cost-share up to \$24.8 million to support response activities undertaken since the first confirmed detections of H5 bird flu in Australia, including response activities still underway, building on Australia's substantial investments in H5 bird flu preparedness.

The cost-shared funding commitment follows advice from the Consultative Committee on Emergency Animal Diseases (CCEAD) and will support implementation of a National Emergency Animal Disease Response Plan (EADRP) under the Emergency Animal Disease Response Agreement (EADRA). The plan provides a framework for a coordinated national response while further information is gathered about the detections.

Since the first detection of H5 bird flu in Australia was confirmed on 20 June 2026 in a wild migratory seabird, the response has been swift. Jurisdictions across Australia have rapidly responded including:

- investigation and laboratory testing of sick and dead birds,
- enhanced surveillance of wildlife,
- providing public information and awareness activities to encourage reporting, and
- engagement with veterinarians, wildlife carers and rehabilitators, industry and local communities.

This work is underpinned by national response guidance in the event of an outbreak of H5 bird flu in wildlife, and a national bird flu surveillance strategy.

The initial response costs will be shared in the national interest to help governments continue to respond rapidly, supporting enhanced surveillance, investigation and response activities while the extent of the detections continue to be assessed.

The CCEAD will continue to monitor the situation and provide advice to the NMG as further information becomes available.

As of 21 July 2026, H5 bird flu detections in Australia have been in individual wild seabirds in Western Australia, South Australia and New South Wales. There are no detections in poultry or other livestock, no evidence of spread to local wildlife, and no large-scale deaths in any animals. At this stage, there is no evidence that H5 bird flu has established in Australian wildlife.

Australia has been well prepared for the arrival of H5 bird flu. Over several years Australian governments have worked together to strengthen national governance and establish cost-sharing arrangements in the event of an outbreak of H5 bird flu in wildlife and have tested these arrangements through scenario-based exercises.

Jurisdictions have actively invested in H5 bird flu preparedness. Since 2024 the Australian Government has committed more than \$113 million to strengthen surveillance, preparedness and response capability for a potential incursion. Planning was carried out by all jurisdictions, supported by a multi-agency taskforce to oversee national coordination through a One Health approach involving animal health, environmental and public health partners.

If it is determined that H5 bird flu cannot be contained or eradicated, the nationally agreed National Management Agreement – H5 HPAI in Wildlife (the H5 NMA) is in place to manage any ongoing impacts in wildlife and risks to animal and human health.

Australian poultry remains free of H5 bird flu. Food Standards Australia New Zealand has advised that poultry and eggs are safe to eat, and that people should always follow good hygiene practices when handling and preparing food.

Reporting suspicion of emergency animal diseases is easy and vital in protecting Australia. Early detection enables a rapid response and improves the likelihood of successful management.

If you notice any sick or dead birds, including domestic poultry, captive or wild birds, do not touch them. Contact the 24/7 Emergency Animal Disease Hotline on 1800 675 888 from anywhere in Australia. Further information about H5 bird flu is available at birdflu.gov.au.

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/about/news/stay-informed/communiques/national-management-group-communique-21-july-2026-h5>